To: United Nations Office for Disarmament Affairs (UNODA)

From: Carter Musheno, Kevin and Xocas Alvarez

Re: The Rhetoric-Action Gap in Multilateral Arms Control

The Problem

Our report finds that international actors are increasingly diverging from promises made within diplomatic agreements regarding ballistic arms limitations and export controls. Our approach applies natural language processing (NLP) techniques across a corpus of United Nations speeches and voting records, V-Dem regime data, Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) Arms Transfers data, and scraped-text from 70 arms treaties across the last 50 years (1970 to 2023). Through our analysis, we highlight a statistically significant gap between international arms control rhetoric and individual state action.

Key Findings

- **Nuclear Weapon States (NWS) - Non-Nuclear Weapon States (NNWS) divide:** Nuclear and non-nuclear weapon states have diverged sharply since 2013. Non-nuclear states support Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons (TPNW) resolutions at a rate of 90% while nuclear states remain consistently at a rate of 0%.
- **Autocracy paradox:** NAM autocracies vote against armament at high rates but their speeches emphasize sovereignty and anti-colonialism more than humanitarian-based or adjacent language.
- **Exporter convergence:** Members of the P5 (China, U.S., France, Russia, U.K.) consistently use similar arms control language while *despite* differentiating on political structure, alliances, regime type, etc. This could indicate material interest shapes rhetoric more than ideology.
- **Lead-lag inconsistency:** Arms Trade Treaty (ATT) ratifiers adopted treaty language

four years before signing; Ottawa ratifiers shifted rhetoric only after. This may indicate that rhetorical alignment is relatively unrelated to treaty adopton.

- **Humanitarian turn:** Humanitarian framing rose sharply after 1975 and plateaued in the 1990s, although this masks behavioral actions.

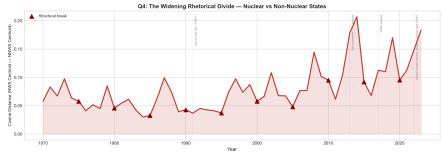


Figure 1: NWS-NNWS rhetorical distance, 1970–2023.

Policy Recommendations

- Require NPT Review Conference delegations to reconcile stated positions with their voting records and treaty participation.
- Link ATT compliance review to consistency between export rhetoric and actual transfer patterns.
- Support a civil-society accountability index scoring each state's rhetoric-action gap annually.

Likely Objections

- Compliance review on 'rhetoric-action consistency' may lead to arbitrary adjustment of rhetoric / actions to satisfy this measure, which may lead to unwanted outcomes like unclear statements (loses meaning as metric becomes target)
- Increased scrutiny may reduce transparency rather than increasing it, in which states becomes more vague in public settings, given the existence of underlying motives of states as seen from data.
- A civil-society accountability index may lack enforcement power, especially to major powers (i.e P5) and unfairly impact smaller states.